

VertiGO!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 664 March 2004 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House,¹ on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar² at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business. Don't be late or you'll miss the legendary quiz draw from President Nigel Roberts. Forget politics, it's his quizzes that make him famous. Tea and coffee after the talk so you can plan more trips and meet new people to climb with!



Section night: March 1st:

IT'S BACK! – SHORT TALKS 1 FOR 2004

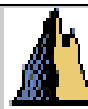
Come along for an evening of short talks from section members on various trips they've undertaken. Stunning photos, funny anecdotes, inspiring tales, what better way to spend a Monday evening?



Pete McGregor - camp scene is on the moraine flats below the Evans Glacier.

¹ On Bowen Street, squashed behind the Treasury on Number 1 the Terrace.

² On Molesworth Street, opposite Parliament.



Section trips news

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.

Mt Whitcombe – a non-ascent

In the second week of January, Wellington Section members Terry Crippen, Andrew Lynch and Pete McGregor teamed up with overseas (Bristol, UK) member Jonathan Astin for an attempt on Mt Whitcombe. We flew in to Smyth Hut at the head of the Wanganui River on a brilliantly fine, hot afternoon, reconnoitred the route as far as Vane Stream, and the next day battled our way up to the moraine flats below the Evans glacier in progressively deteriorating weather. Faced with a grim forecast, we squelched, waded and scrub-bashed back down to the hut the next day, soaked our tired bodies in some of the best wilderness hot pools in the country and woke the following morning to a brilliantly fine day.

So we set off back up the river to climb Mt Lord. The ascent proved to be a simple trudge, with the only semblance of technical climbing being among the Evans river boulders. The rewards were spectacular views of Snow Dome and Whitcombe beyond the distinctly un-menacing Menace Gap; a direct view of the impressive north face of Dan Peak; an airy panorama across the beautiful Lord Valley to Mt Stoddart and the edge of the Garden of Allah; and valleys, peaks, glaciers and glittering thread-like streams and rivers far below. During the descent and return to the hut, mare's tails and wispy cirrus thickened into a dark overcast sky, but the rain held off until after we'd soaked weary bones in the hot pools.

Two days of rain, hail and sleet-watching followed. During that period, Whataroa received 378 mm of rain in 24 hours; the Collier Gorge swing bridge in the Whitcombe was washed away; Ferguson Bush just north of Harihari was devastated by floods, and thunder from lightning was drowned by the thunder of huge boulders rumbling down the violently flooded river. Pancakes and rolled oat pikelets were made and eaten, lunches shared, innumerable brews drunk, the dangers of square-cut Tararua biscuits discussed, and the hut library well-utilised.

The walk downriver to Hunter's Hut proved eventful when we were negotiating the unstable face of a high river terrace. We picked our way carefully across unstable, porridge-like scree and boulders, nervously watching the trickle of stones and muck from above; a nervousness that was confirmed as fully justified when I heard a thump and rumble and looked up to see huge boulders – some the size of a coffee table – hurtling down towards Jonathan and Terry. Jonathan scrambled back towards me, but for a horrible moment I thought Terry was about to be killed. Fortunately, the leaping and bounding rocks missed him. Faced with the prospect of being pulverised, Andrew promptly put his helmet on. He then bolted across a particularly dodgy-looking section, seconds before the face released even larger boulders, bouncing and thundering down between him and us. It carried a whole tree partway down the face, rocks and debris continuing to fall long after the main event. Yes, that helmet was a good idea.

By now, any attempt to join Andrew on the far side would have been suicidal. We abandoned the idea, and instead climbed a more stable section of the face, negotiating a final tricky lip to gain the bush on top of the terrace. We then bush-bashed around the top of the slip and down to rejoin Andrew (who by this time had lured immense squadrons of sandflies from the surrounding bush). Hunter's Hut that evening seemed very tranquil. We walked out the next day, and drank beer and ate pizza at the Harihari Pub under the glaring, dusty eye of a stuffed

ferret, snarling from the wall. Below it on badly hand cut piece of paper was the stencilled word "FERRET". Just in case you didn't know. The perfect end to a memorable West Coast trip.

Pete McGregor

A Hopeless Shark's Tooth

Mt Hopeless: Weekend before Chrissy, Amanda Taylor, Mark McDonald, Ron Stutter and John Nankervis went into Cupola Hut. Weather didn't clear until 11am on the planned climbing day but they went up the Couloir to the top and then traversed down the South Ridge. In the mist almost lost the keyhole to the step on the ridge and then, later, the hut in the night. The walk out day was perfect.

John Cocks, Russell Braddock, Paul Denys and John Nankervis went on their ritual New Years weekend trip. Great ambitions but.... They were driven back to the car park by rain from a camp on Cascade Saddle. They then climbed Shark's Tooth. This is an impressive rock fang when viewed from the ablutions block in the Raspberry car park but in truth the scrambling gets delicate only in the last 100 metres.

John Nankervis

Palmie North news!

Terry Crippen and Jonathan Astin (of Mt Whitcombe non-ascent fame – see above) had a successful spell in the Aspiring area. Chopped into Bevan Col (to make the best use of the variable weather and to make it easier on some damaged ribs). After enduring an over-full hut of 19 bods in some grotty weather, the hut emptied out leaving just us and one other pair. The following day the four of us climbed Aspiring via Shipowner and NW ridges and had the summit to ourselves. We also wandered up Rolling Pin and the grotty rock of Bevan which we found less inviting than Aspiring's NW ridge.

Later on, after dropping back down into the West Matukituki, we slogged our way up the steep stream opposite Wilson's Camp Stream, to a high camp of about 1600m to have a go at Rob Roy. From here we had a long hot traverse up the Rob Roy Glacier onto the summit.

Terry Crippen



39 Mercer Street, PO Box 1560, Wellington, New Zealand
Ph/Fax (04) 47 35353 email mainly.tramping@paradise.net.nz

Adventures of the Chicken-Counters – Sea to the Summit of Mt Sefton 14-21 Jan

Yet again the intrepid Johnny Mulheron and an assortment of mad transalpinists achieved a significant summit (Mt Sefton) starting from a wild West Coast beach. With mountain biking, tramping and a great time on the tops, the trip finished off with a leisurely ride down the Karangarua River, returning to the Tasman Sea.

The party had a true Viking (Erik Bradshaw) as its water specialist, providing unsinkable rafts, PFD's and makeshift paddles). These needed to be light enough to be carried up river on Day 1, along with packs full of provisions for 7 days – we were not going to starve. But Erik had more weight saving ideas than the rest of us – carrying just one ice tool: his prototype ice-axe head attached securely to a telescopic trekking pole. Thus saving a kilo of weight and multi-tasking as a walking stick, ice-axe, avalanche probe, snow shovel handle and raft paddle handle!

Once the vegetated slabs beside Scotts Creek waterfall had been mounted (Jonathan's favourite part of the trip with feelings of deja-vu when his pack was once again subjected to a 30m tumble), a great night was had at Welcome Pass and alarms were eagerly (? Ed.) set for 4am to maximise the fine weather window hoped for the following day.

A quick ascent of Sefton the following morning was followed by an early lunch back at the Pass by 10.45. We didn't hang around basking in the sun on the Douglas Neve, as our destination for that night was Horace Walker Hut beside the Douglas River, and the route espoused by a "tramping party" who had ascended from Horace Walker a few years ago sounded dubious but worth investigating.

After several attempts at finding a safe route down the Douglas Neve below the ice-falls of Blizzard Peak, and with a real blizzard imminent, we took the alternate route over Lucy Walker Pass and sidled around Pioneer Peak to an easy glissading descent and bush-bash into the valley.

Always the optimist (we had been now going for over 14 hrs), Johnny viewing the riverbed from over 1000m above, was heard to say "there's probably sinking sand down there" and we all mocked him and counted more chickens: something we all lived to regret. Two hours later all covered in mud (except the elusive Johnny), we were lucky to have escaped the lethal mire and to reach the hut by 10pm. A rest day was welcomed the next day as a storm passed through and hundreds of waterfalls appeared on the cliffs opposite the hut. The high rivers limited our options so we took the high road and sidled across Thar country and skirmished with Leatherwood enroute to Cassell Flat Hut.

On several occasions Jonathan reminded us that we shouldn't count our chickens – with plenty of possible obstacles (like the sinking sand) which could hold us up...and sure enough there were! Overgrown tracks, steep slippery slabs, a damaged knee ligament for our aged sandbagger and then, just as the end was in sight, the cableway across the flooded Karangarua was unserviceable (without a rope, and the cablecar cage tied up on the other side). But this was not enough to stop Erik the Viking, who went across hand over hand for 60m to reach the cage for us.

Now all that remained was a few hours of spectacular West Coast tramping, a sprained ankle for Jonathan, and more fun in the water – crossing the head deep but "nice and warm" glacial grey Copland River, and rafting down to the sea, counting chickens and Kahikateas all the way...

The river section from the highway to the coast took over 4 hours, and involved lots of paddling, piracy and photography in the lingering sunset. At 10pm we reached the lagoon at the Coast with the turbulent waves of an in-coming tide fighting against the outgoing river...once again we found ourselves swimming in murky depths. "It's only an easy 5km walk down the beach to the car" said one of the still optimistic chicken-counters. Yes, a nice walk – and then some! After almost 2 hours (carrying rafts and saturated packs) grovelling round in the dark through eel infested creeks and estuaries which we had not bothered to identify on the map when planning this section of the trip, we were all grateful to find the car was still there where we had left it a week ago.

What's next Johnny? Coast to Coast via Elie de Beaumont? No problem: I'm sure there will be no chickens on that trip!

Steve Canham. Trip participants: Johnny Mulheron, Erik Bradshaw, Jonathan Kennett, Steve Canham

Postscript: After drying out and a much needed shower, Steve joined up with Jo Holden at Unwin Hut for a climb of Cook. The clear skies and brilliant sunshine held out for the "walk" up Haast Ridge, but with the weather crapping out an attempt for the summit was made on Sunday 25 January. Reaching the Summit Rocks in a treacherous windy white-out, the cattle tracks were being filled in before our eyes. Sheltering in the shrund at the top of the Linda Shelf, the joint decision was made to go down. Thankfully Plateau Hut was not overcrowded (only 4 parties of 2 came and went), and after waiting out the stormy weather for 2 nights, we descended over spectacular Cinerama Col, which was much easier travel than Haast Ridge. All those flying in to bag the peak may have better chances of summiting but with such good scenery and adventure on the walk in, surely they are missing half the fun!



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BANFF IS BACK!

THE BANFF FESTIVAL OF MOUNTAIN FILMS

Keep Sunday night free on your calendar for the 2003/04 world tour of the Banff Mountain Film Festival, brought to Wellington's Paramount Theatre by our section of the NZAC.

As those who attended last year know, this international festival is not to be missed.

A ticket pre-sale for club members will be happening at the APRIL section night. Watch this space in next month's VertiGO for more details.

For more information contact:

Lynn Ayers

ph 977 4914

email la@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

<http://www.banffcentre.ca/mountainculture/tour/>



Section night Coordinator needed!

Kara Lipski has done a fantastic job over the years, it is time for someone else to take a turn! If you are interested in helping out, email rs@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or any other member of the Committee (see contact list at back).



Our website

- Check out our web site: www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz !
- Join the email discussion group!
- New photos and trip reports up!



And here are the club trips...

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, come and chat to Mike Williams (trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email me, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and I can help you get going on a safe and enjoyable trip.

See you in the hills!

Trips currently on the calendar...

Nepal	<i>TBC</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Overseas Expedition	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Steve Hart, email sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
How about a slightly longer trip to Nepal in Oct/Nov 2004? *Update* : Interest steadily grows. With the changing regulations so too do the objectives, one of which is to scale Mt Have-a-Good-Time. Trekking options will be part of this trip. We'll be aiming to stay away from the Everest circus while still utilising the ease of logistics. One of our goals will be an unclimbed peak up to 6500m. If you are interested and willing to be part of a team effort contact Steve.	

Chile	<i>TBC</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Overseas Expedition	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Toto Gronlund, toto.high@ntl-world.com	
The English alpine club are organising a trip to Patagonia in 2004.	

Africa	<i>June 2005</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Mountaineering	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Rachael Schmidt, email rs@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
Plan is to climb Mt Kenya and trek Kili.	

COME ON GUYS – WE NEED MORE TRIPS!



MOVED HOUSE?

Tell:

Margaret McMahon
NZAC Administration Officer
New Zealand Alpine Club
PO BOX 786
CHRISTCHURCH
TEL (03) 377 7595, FAX (03) 337 7594
e mail office@alpineclub.org.nz

Do you have a great photo?

Good enough for the cover of vertiGO? Then send it to:
cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



HANGDOG INDOOR CLIMBING CAVERN

Come down and see us for all your climbing and bouldering needs. We have heaps of good routes from grade 14 through to 30. We have the only bouldering room in Wellington, which we have just enlarged to help aspiring and existing climbers become STRONGER.

Remember that it only costs NZAC members \$9.00 to climb with ID!

Our gear shop now has heaps of new stock, especially alpine kit, including mountaineering ropes, plastic boots, crampons, axes plus a great range of general hardware and stacks of new rock shoes. For an example this weeks specials are Faders Quick draws RRP\$33 down to only \$19 and Austri-Alpine Steel Karabiners RRP\$49 down to \$20.

We want to stock our shop to suit club members gear requirements....let us know what you need!

HangDog and Top Adventures
453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181

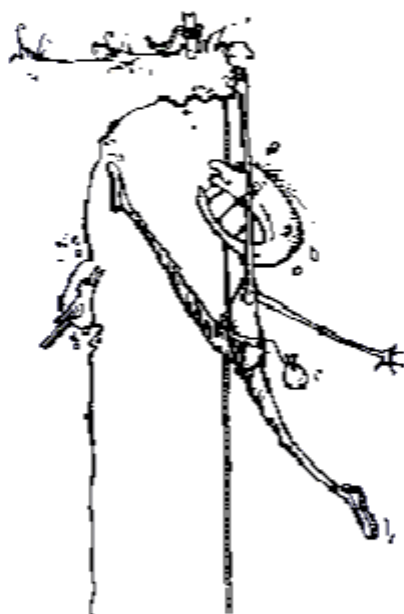


Wellington Section Directory: 2004 contact list

Please notify the Club's National Administrator of your change of address as the labels for all newsletters and club publications are generated at the HQ office. You can contact:

Position	Name	E-mail Alias*	Phone
Patron	Judy Reid	N/A	N/A
Chairperson	Nigel Roberts	CHAIRPERSON <i>or</i> NR	(04) 475 7543
Vice Chairpersons	Pete De Joux	PDJ <i>or</i> PD	(04) 478 1017
	Steve Hart	SH	N/A
Secretary	Rachael Schmidt	SECRETARY <i>or</i> RS	(04) 470 4479
Treasurer	Caroline Duggan	TREASURER <i>or</i> CD	(04) 475 5542
National Representative	Caroline Duggan	CD	(04) 475 5542
	Nigel Roberts	NR	(04) 475 7543
Instruction: AIC	Pete de Joux	AIC	(04) 478 1017
Instruction: RIC	Scott Taylor	SPRINGROCK	N/A
Trips	Mike Williams	TRIPS <i>or</i> MW	(04) 973 2995
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	(04) 934 7926
Committee Members	Lynn Ayers	LA	(04) 977 4914
	Michele Domaneschi	MD	N/A
	Garth London	GL	(04) 479 2984
	Alan Lowrie	AL	N/A
	Mike O'Brien	MOB	(04) 380 0913
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	(04) 934 7926
	Mike Williams	MW	(04) 973 2995
National President	Dave Bamford	DB	N/A
Palmerston North Contact	John Barnes	JB	(06) 357 0654
Newsletter Editor	Rachael Schmidt	RS	(04) 470 4479
Section Night Admin	Lynn Ayers	LA	N/A
Webmeister	Jane Furkert	WEBMASTER <i>or</i> JF	N/A

* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



If undelivered please return to:

NZAC Wellington Section
PO Box 1628
Wellington

